

The Maasai of Matapato

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 31

Culture (OWC): Maasai (FL12)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: July 1976-September 1977

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Matapato, Kenya

Section Title(S): THE REMOVAL OF THE BRIDE

The journey to the husband's village should be uneventful. The best man leads the way, removing debris from her path and carrying her over any flowing water that might wash away the blessing. For most of the journey, she remains a lonely figure in an unfamiliar area, dragging her steps some distance behind the two men. The climax of this journey is her reception at her husband's village, when once more she is the butt of a joke, bringing her isolation to a head. She is left by herself outside this village, and is then greeted by the women, who come out to taunt her persistently until she breaks down in tears. They may tease her for being her husband's current favourite who will in her turn be discarded. They pretend to rummage through her belongings to discover a hidden store of tobacco and prove that already she has the secret habits of an old woman and has never been taught a full sense of respect. She is no longer a girl and now even girls come out to taunt her. These are jokes that point up some of the sombre realities of wifehood, and mark the most radical transition in her life with a totally new role and surrounded by new faces.

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Humor

578

Ingroup Antagonisms

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Nuptials

She is then left alone, and there follows a series of friendly approaches by those women who are closely related to her husband. Each in turn comes to confer (*a-imal*) a gift of respect to entice her to enter the village: ideally a cow, or a sheep or goat, or a lesser item according to the giver's means. Later the husband's full brothers and sons - those who should avoid her sexually - make similar gifts as a token of respect between them. In future the bride and donor address (*a-imal*) each other by a reciprocal term of respect making these welcoming gifts a memorable feature of her homecoming: ' *pa-heifer* ', ' *pa-calf* ', ' *pa-goat* ', and so on. In this mixed reception at her new home, the transition *girl/outsider[unknown] wife/insider* entails a display of

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Gift Giving

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Nuptials

disrespect/hostility[unknown] respect/friendliness , symbolised by the *taunting[unknown] gift giving* . For the girl, this mixed reception may entail an  32 element of brain-washing, confusing her up to a point, degrading her for what she has been, but also promising her a future in her husband's home. For the other women, it may entail an outlet for their hostility towards the newcomer who has received so much attention, after which they can more readily accept her. Beyond this, the juxtaposition of taunting and gift-giving may also be felt to anticipate the ambiguities of the various relationships the bride will form in her new home.

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